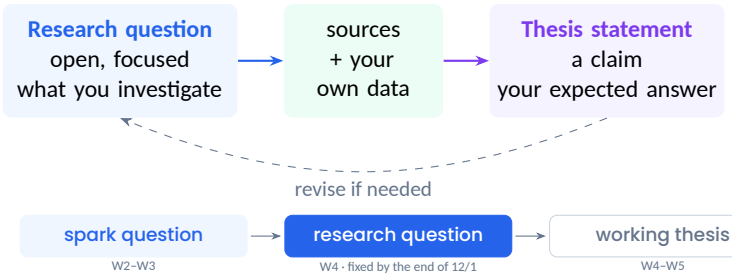
Worksheet W4 · W-Seminar "Time"

Research question and thesis

From a topic to a question you can answer – and to the claim you will put to the test.

1 A question and its answer



Your question grows. From now on every worksheet has a box **My question – version n**: improve your last version, note what changed and why. Keep the old versions – they show how your research developed.



In your own words: how do question and thesis work together?

2 Six markers of a good research question

Focused Who or what exactly? Where, when?
Open no one-search answer, no plain yes/no, no built-in answer
Researchable Are there sources to build on?
Open question words: *How … / To what extent … / In what ways … / Why …*

Testable Can I collect my own data?
Feasible 10–15 pages? Time, access, ethics?
Relevant So what? And is it about time?

3 Spot the problem

Which marker does each question miss most? Then improve one of them.

question	missing marker
a) What is the Mayan calendar?	
b) How does time affect people?	
c) Will humans ever travel back in time?	
d) How did all English novels of the 20th century deal with time?	

My improved version of _____ :

4 From question to thesis

A thesis statement …

- **answers** the question directly
- is **arguable** – not a fact, not a taste
- is **specific** – group, material, direction
- is **testable** – a result could prove it wrong
- is **short** – one or two sentences

Question: To what extent does checking a phone during homework change how long students think they worked?

Your working thesis:

5 Work phase: read to orient

10 min · aim for 1–3 options by the end of today

My spark: _____

Keywords (English): _____

Names (researchers, authors, works): _____

A debate – where do people disagree? _____

strategies + builder

6 Question storm

5 min · at least 10 questions · no judging · then mark O (open) / C (closed) and star your best three

7 My question – version 1

three candidates

spark → question → working thesis → testable claim → thesis

	research question	working thesis	my own data – from whom?
1			
2			
3			

8 Draw the line – for your strongest option

In material · people · time span · aspect · method

Out – on purpose

This paper focuses on _____

It does not _____

9 Partner check

- ☐ So what – who would want to know?
- ☐ What exactly will you collect, from whom?
- ☐ Which result would prove your thesis wrong?
- ☐ Too big, too small – or right for 10–15 pages?

My partner's tip · my next step